Modi concluded his 2014 campaign by addressing his last rally in Ballia in eastern UP. His publicists were quick to provide the details. Their leader had done 437 rallies and covered more than 3 lakh kilometres since being anointed the BJP's prime ministerial candidate in mid-September. But if he was tired, he wasn't showing any signs of it.

On the way back from Ballia, he stopped at Varanasi airport where his trusted aides, Jaitley and Shah, were waiting for him. The troika who had shaped the BJP's 2014 campaign then flew back together to Delhi. 'There was a feeling of deep satisfaction amongst all of us. Narendra was convinced that victory was ours and Mission 272-plus would be reality—there was no self-doubt at all,' Jaitley told me later.

On arrival in Delhi, Modi made a quick stopover at the RSS headquarters at Jhandewalan where he met the RSS chief Mohan Bhagwat. It was a reminder that even as a prime ministerial nominee, he was first and always a swayamsevak. It was also perhaps a thanksgiving to Bhagwat. After all, the Sangh with its well-drilled cadres had come out in almost full strength to provide the organizational support and feet on the ground for Modi and the BJP in this election. Indeed, the RSS had pulled out all the stops—grass-roots organizers, campaigners and mobilizers—perhaps as enthusiastically as it had done in the JP movement against Indira's Emergency. With a targeted door-to-door campaign, they had been Modi's last-mile warriors.

The same night Modi flew back to Gandhinagar. The most gruelling campaign in the history of Indian elections was over. Modi had run a marathon with unbelievable stamina. 7, Race Course Road, the most cherished address in Indian politics, was now well within his grasp.